

E-Commerce Website Setup Guide

Platform selection, product catalogue setup, payment integration, launch checklist, and post-launch optimization — a complete path from choosing a platform to running a store that keeps improving after launch.

1. Platform Selection Matrix

Pricing and fee structures below are approximate and change frequently — all three platforms listed have changed pricing or fee structures within the past year. Verify current pricing, transaction fees, and any sales-volume thresholds directly with each vendor before deciding.

Platform	Best For	Approx. Entry Price	Transaction Fees	Key Trade-off
Shopify	Fastest path to launch; largest app ecosystem	~\$29-39/mo, scaling up by tier	Waived if using the platform's own payment processor; apply otherwise	Easiest to launch and staff, but ongoing app costs add up at scale
BigCommerce	Stores needing strong native B2B/catalog features without heavy app reliance	~\$29-39/mo, scaling up by tier	Historically fee-free on approved processors; recent changes added fees for non-approved gateways — verify current terms	More built-in features reduce app costs, but plans can auto-upgrade based on sales volume thresholds
WooCommerce (WordPress)	Businesses wanting full ownership of the platform and maximum long-term flexibility	Free plugin; hosting + extensions cost separately	Depends entirely on chosen payment gateway, not the platform itself	Most flexible and portable, but you own all hosting, updates, and security
Squarespace / Wix Commerce	Small catalogs, simplicity over flexibility	~\$25-40/mo	Varies by plan and payment method	Fastest and simplest for a small catalog, but limited as product complexity grows

2. Product Setup Guide

Incomplete or inconsistent product data is one of the most common reasons a new store looks unfinished, even when the design itself is polished.

Essential Product Data

Field	Guidance
Title	Specific and searchable — include the attributes a customer would actually search for (material, size, key feature)
Description	Lead with the benefit to the customer, not just a specification list — specs matter, but they answer a different question than “why should I want this?”
Images	Multiple angles, consistent lighting and background across the whole catalog, and at least one image showing scale or context of use
Price and SKU	Consistent SKU format across the catalog makes inventory and reporting dramatically easier later
Variants (size, color, etc.)	Set up variant structure before adding many products — restructuring variants after the catalog is large is disproportionately painful
Inventory tracking	Enable stock tracking from day one, even if inventory is currently simple — retrofitting it later means auditing the entire catalog
Category / Collection	Organize around how customers actually browse and search, not just your internal supplier or product-line structure

SEO Basics for Product Pages

- Unique title tag and meta description per product — never leave these as platform defaults across the whole catalog
- Descriptive, unique image alt text, not just the filename
- Structured data (schema markup) for products where your platform supports it, to enable rich search results (price, availability, ratings)

3. Payment Integration Checklist

Always use an established, PCI-compliant payment processor (e.g. the platform's built-in payments, Stripe, PayPal, or similar) rather than building any custom system that stores or transmits raw card data. Handling card data directly carries serious compliance obligations (PCI DSS) and security risk that established processors are specifically built to handle correctly.

Before Going Live

- ☐ Payment gateway selected and confirmed to be PCI-compliant (nearly all major processors are; confirm rather than assume for less common ones)
- ☐ Full checkout flow tested in the processor's sandbox/test mode, including a simulated failed payment
- ☐ Multiple payment methods supported where relevant to your customers (major cards, and common digital wallets like Apple Pay/Google Pay)
- ☐ Currency and tax calculation configured correctly for every region you actually sell to
- ☐ Refund and chargeback process documented and understood by whoever will handle customer service
- ☐ Fraud detection/prevention tools enabled (most major processors and platforms include baseline tools by default)
- ☐ Site-wide HTTPS confirmed, not just on the checkout page

4. Launch Checklist

- [] Complete purchase flow tested end-to-end on both desktop and mobile: browse, add to cart, checkout, payment, confirmation email received
- [] Shipping rates and delivery estimates configured and verified as accurate
- [] Order notification emails (customer confirmation, internal new-order alert) tested and arriving correctly
- [] Legal pages published: Terms of Service, Privacy Policy, Returns/Refund Policy
- [] Analytics and conversion tracking installed and verified to be firing correctly, not just installed
- [] 404 and error pages configured, not left as generic platform defaults
- [] Site tested across at least two browsers and both major mobile operating systems
- [] A soft-launch or limited release considered before a full marketing push, to catch issues with lower stakes

5. Post-Launch Optimization Plan

Launch is the beginning of the store's real work, not the end of the project — the highest-value improvements usually come from real customer behavior data you can't have before launch.

Area	What to Do	Cadence
Cart abandonment	Monitor the rate; if high, review checkout friction and consider abandoned-cart recovery emails	Weekly review
Checkout and product page testing	A/B test one meaningful change at a time — checkout flow and primary product images tend to have the highest impact	Ongoing, one test at a time
SEO and content	Expand product descriptions and add supporting content (buying guides, FAQs) for pages with real search traffic potential	Monthly
Customer feedback	Review support tickets and reviews for recurring themes — patterns here often reveal product page gaps or unclear policies	Monthly
Performance and uptime	Monitor page speed and uptime; a slow or occasionally-down store quietly costs more in lost sales than most owners realize	Ongoing, automated monitoring